

Influential brokers got a free run because the governing board of the stock exchange was packed with broker members. On paper, the stock exchange was answerable to the Ministry of Finance, but the government nominees rarely attended meetings of the governing board. In effect, the exchange was controlled by a clique of influential brokers, to such an extent that many joked that BSE was an abbreviation for Brokers' Stock Exchange and not of Bombay Stock Exchange. Naturally, disciplinary action against erring members was rare. Occasionally a broker would be penalized, but the fines were insignificant.

Cartel wars in a stock were quite common at the time, and usually saw the Marwari brokers arrayed on one side and the Gujarati brokers on the other. One group would take a bullish view on a stock, and the other would try its best to hammer the price of that stock down. Having friends in the stock exchange governing board or in the company helped tilt the balance of power. Bulls could be caught on the wrong foot if the stock exchange suddenly increased the margin on buy trades, and bears could be trapped by a sudden wave of buying, usually by players funded by company promoters. India was still a closed economy then, and stock market players did not look beyond the stocks whose companies they had an interest (usually vested) in.

My jobbing skills were steadily improving, and in a good month I would take home close to Rs 10,000.

Occasionally I ended up annoying some of the big players of the game. Once Manubhai Manek asked me to buy a block of shares of a certain stock. It so happened that his son-in-law, who sat a few offices away from Manek's, wanted to sell a block of that same lot. I got him the block he wanted, and charged him the usual brokerage of 1.5 per cent.

A few days later Manubhai learnt the identity of the seller and was miffed with me. 'You could have told me that my son-in-law was looking to sell the block,' he told me when we bumped into each other in the ring. I grinned at him, but Manubhai was not amused.

'You should be called *chakku* (knife); you could slit somebody's throat to earn a commission,' he said.

But only a week later he made me an offer when we met in the ring.

'Hey *chakku*, what is your boss paying you?' he asked.

If it had been anybody else I might have asked him to get lost. But this was Manubhai himself, whom I had managed to get on the wrong side of